Nanak Niwas hideout, was planned by the director general, security, and presented to Indira Gandhi for her approval at her residential office, 1 Akbar Road, in the presence of Senior Advisor R.N. Kao.

However, Gandhi shot it down citing unaffordable civilian casualties that could result from it. Though the article was an excellent piece of investigative journalism, it had a few discrepancies, a major one being that when that operation was planned, Bhindranwale had already shifted to the Akal Takht and was no longer at Guru Nanak Niwas. Second, the plan was to grab him while he was delivering his sermon from the langar roof, and not from his room in Guru Nanak Niwas. [8]

It may be mentioned here that this was not the first attempt or plan by the SFF or the Indian army or security forces to arrest or abduct Bhindranwale from his hideouts. One such attempt at getting the army involved in his arrest from Chowk Mehta gurudwara after Lala Jagat Narain's murder in September 1981 has been described in Chapter 3.

Kao was even planning an SFF-led heliborne operation to abduct Bhindranwale from Chowk Mehta before the latter shifted to Guru Nanak Niwas on 19 July 1982. Sometime in the second half of June 1982, Director (R) Suntook called me to ascertain if it would be feasible for me to do a 'casing' (reconnaissance and preparation of a detailed map of the targeted area) of the Chowk Mehta complex. After a detailed discussion of the pros and cons of my 'casing' visit, I told Suntook that there was every chance of my being recognized by somebody at the complex, which could in turn alert Bhindranwale about the likelihood of such an operation.

I later learnt that someone else from the R&AW was actually sent to 'case' the Chowk Mehta complex under the guise of a reporter, but he was chased out as a suspected intelligence agent. Most likely it was this visit of a R&AW officer, followed by the arrest of Amrik Singh and Thara Singh on 19 July 1982, that prompted Bhindranwale to seek refuge in the safety of Guru Nanak Niwas.

To this day I have not been able to figure out the real motive behind the 'casing' operation. Possibly, Kao wanted to collect all relevant information well in advance, which could be useful when a